MANDARIN ZEST
中文皮

COMPLETE BEGINNER WORKBOOK

# Your First Steps in Mandarin Chinese

Pinyin · 20 essential characters · your first conversation

你好

- 拼 **Pinyin made simple**
  Every sound and all five tones
- 写 **Stroke by stroke**
  20 characters with practice grids
- 说 **Say it out loud**
  A real dialogue using only what you learned



mandarinzest.com

WELCOME

# From Zero to Your First Conversation



This workbook is your very first session with Mandarin. No prior knowledge needed. By the last page you will be able to pronounce any word written in pinyin, write 20 real Chinese characters stroke by stroke, and read a short conversation entirely in characters.

## Every character in the final dialogue is one you will have written yourself.

## What's inside

### 01
**Pinyin**

The sound system: syllables, initials, finals, and the five tones, with the spelling rules beginners trip over.

### 02
**Writing**

The 8 basic strokes, the stroke order rules, and 20 carefully chosen characters, each with a practice grid.

### 03
**Speaking**

Your first dialogue: greeting someone and asking their name, built only from the 20 characters you just learned.

## How to use this workbook

1. **Say everything out loud.** Pinyin is useless if it stays silent. Read every example in your loudest voice, tones exaggerated.
2. **Work in short sessions.** Three or four characters a day is plenty. Twenty minutes of focus beats two distracted hours.
3. **Trace, then write.** Copy the model, trace the grey characters, then fill the empty squares from memory.
4. **Come back tomorrow.** Before starting new characters, rewrite yesterday's from memory. That review is where they stick.

**Ready? 我们开始吧！** Wǒmen kāishǐ ba! Let's begin!

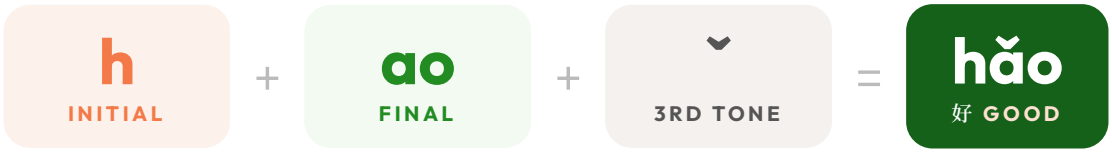
# 01 PART 1 Pinyin: How Mandarin Sounds

音
yīn · sound

> Pinyin spells Chinese sounds with the Latin alphabet. It is your pronunciation map: you'll use it to read new words aloud until the characters become familiar.

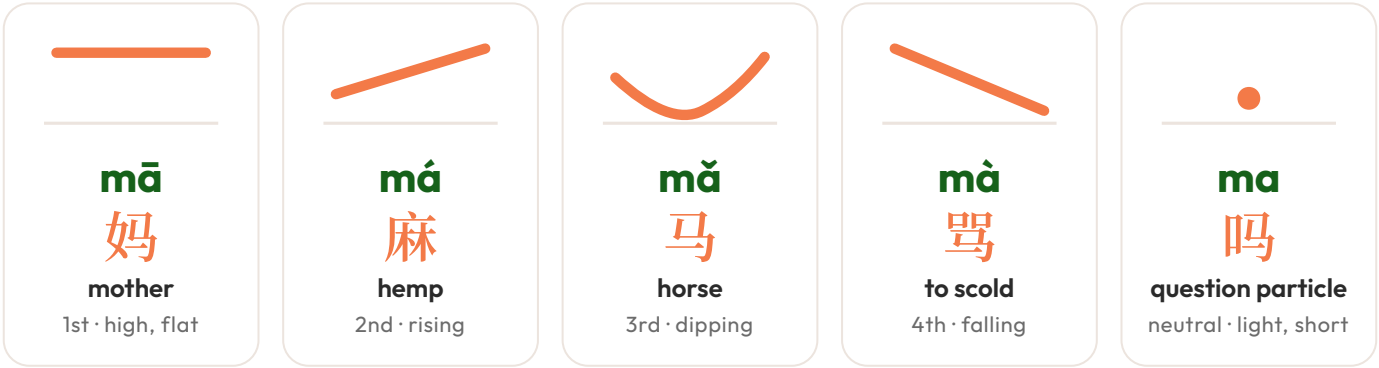
## 1.1 Anatomy of a syllable

Almost every Mandarin syllable has three parts: an **initial** (the starting consonant), a **final** (the vowel part), and a **tone** (the pitch). Some syllables have no initial at all, like ài or è.




## 1.2 The five tones

Change the pitch and you change the word. Say each one out loud, exaggerating the movement of your voice:




WATCH & LISTEN
**How do tones change the meaning of Chinese words?**
Mandarin Zest on YouTube · tap to play →

**WHERE DOES THE TONE MARK GO?**

On **a** or **e** whenever there is one: hǎo, yuè. In **ou**, it goes on the o: gǒu. Otherwise, on the last vowel: liù, guì.

**TWO TONE CHANGES TO KNOW NOW**

**3 + 3 → 2 + 3:** 你好 is written nǐ hǎo but said **ní hǎo**.

不 **before a 4th tone → bú:** 不是 is said **bú shì**.

## 1.3 Initials: the 21 starting sounds

Grouped by where your mouth makes the sound. Pay special attention to the **puff of air**: b/p, d/t, g/k and z/c are pairs that differ only by how much air you push out.

### LIPS

| | |
|---|---|
| **b** | like p in "spy," no puff of air |
| **p** | like p in "pie," with a strong puff |
| **m** | as in "me" |
| **f** | as in "fun" |

### TONGUE TIP

| | |
|---|---|
| **d** | like t in "sty," no puff |
| **t** | like t in "top," with a puff |
| **n** | as in "no" |
| **l** | as in "low" |

### BACK OF THE THROAT

| | |
|---|---|
| **g** | like k in "sky," no puff |
| **k** | like k in "kite," with a puff |
| **h** | breathy, close to ch in Scottish "loch" |

### TONGUE FLAT, SMILE

| | |
|---|---|
| **j** | like j in "jeep" |
| **q** | like ch in "cheap" |
| **x** | like sh in "sheep" |

### TONGUE CURLED BACK

| | |
|---|---|
| **zh** | like j in "jerk" |
| **ch** | like ch in "church" |
| **sh** | like sh in "shirt" |
| **r** | a curled r, close to s in "pleasure" |

### TONGUE BEHIND TEETH

| | |
|---|---|
| **z** | like ds in "kids" |
| **c** | like ts in "cats," with a puff |
| **s** | as in "sun" |

## 1.4 Finals: the vowel part

### SIMPLE

| | |
|---|---|
| **a** | "ah" as in father |
| **o** | "aw," close to wo |
| **e** | "uh" as in the |
| **i** | "ee" as in see |
| **u** | "oo" as in food |
| **ü** | "ee" with rounded lips |

### PAIRS

| | |
|---|---|
| **ai** | "eye" |
| **ei** | "ay" as in day |
| **ao** | "ow" as in cow |
| **ou** | "oh" as in go |
| **er** | like American "are" |

### NASAL

| | |
|---|---|
| **an** | "ahn" |
| **en** | "un" as in taken |
| **ang** | "ahng" |
| **eng** | "ung" as in lung |
| **ong** | "oong" |

### STARTING WITH I

| | |
|---|---|
| **ia ie iao iu** | ya · yeh · yow · yo |
| **ian** | "yen" (not "yan") |
| **in ing** | een · eeng |
| **iang iong** | yahng · yoong |

### STARTING WITH U

| | |
|---|---|
| **ua uo uai** | wah · waw · why |
| **ui un** | way · wun |
| **uan uang** | wahn · wahng |

### STARTING WITH Ü

| | |
|---|---|
| **üe üan ün** | ü + eh · ü + en · ü + n |

### SPELLING QUIRKS THAT TRIP UP BEGINNERS

- **ü loses its dots** after j, q, x and y: ju, qu, xu, yu all use the ü sound. Only after n and l do you see the dots (nǚ, lǜ).
- **i is not always "ee."** After z, c, s, zh, ch, sh and r it becomes a buzzing sound, as in zì 字 and shì 是.
- **y and w are just spellings.** yi sounds like i, wu like u, and yue is üe, as in yuè 月.
- **iu, ui and un are short forms** of iou, uei and uen. Say the hidden vowel lightly: liù sounds close to "lyo."

# 02 PART 2 Writing Your First Characters

写
xiě · to write

Every character is built from a small set of strokes, written in a fixed order. Learn the order once and even complex characters become a sequence of simple moves.

## 2.1 The 8 basic strokes

| 横 héng | 竖 shù | 撇 piě | 捺 nà | 点 diǎn | 提 tí | 折 zhé | 钩 gōu |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Horizontal | Vertical | Left-falling | Right-falling | Dot | Rising | Turning | Hook |

## 2.2 Seven stroke order rules

These cover nearly every character you'll meet as a beginner. The example beside each rule is one of your 20 characters.

是 **Top before bottom**
Write the upper parts of a character first.

你 **Left before right**
The left component comes before the right one.

什 **Horizontal before vertical**
When strokes cross, the horizontal usually goes first.

人 **Left-falling before right-falling**
The stroke sweeping left comes before the one sweeping right.

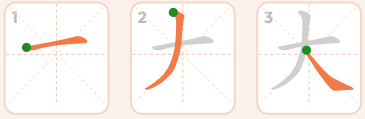
月 **Outside before inside**
Build the frame, then fill it in.

日 **Fill in, then close**
A box gets its bottom stroke last.

小 **Middle before sides**
A strong centre stroke goes before its smaller side strokes.

! **When in doubt, check**
A few characters break the rules. That's what the diagrams are for.

## 2.3 How to read the character pages




- The **orange** stroke is the one to write next; grey strokes are already done.
- The **green dot** shows where your pen starts.
- In each grid: copy the model, trace the grey characters, then write the rest from memory.

01

一

## yī one

1 stroke

The simplest character there is: one horizontal stroke, written left to right. It also teaches you the most common stroke in Chinese, the horizontal 横 héng.

LOOK FOR IT IN 大 不 是




02

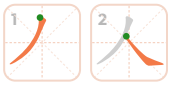
人

## rén person

2 strokes

A person seen from the side, two legs striding forward. Write the left-falling stroke first, then the right-falling one.

LOOK FOR IT IN 大 你 (as 亻) 什 (as 亻)




03

大

## dà big

3 strokes

A person (人) stretching their arms wide (一): "this big!" Horizontal first, then the two legs.

LOOK FOR IT IN 大人 dàrén · adult 大月



04

# 小

## xiǎo small, little

3 strokes

Three small strokes: the middle hook first, then the left dot, then the right one. 小 is also used before names as a friendly nickname.

LOOK FOR IT IN 小月 大小 dàxiǎo · size




小 小 小 小

小 小

05

# 口

## kǒu mouth

3 strokes

A square open mouth. Left side first, then the top and right side in one turning stroke, and close the bottom last. It appears in many characters about speaking.

LOOK FOR IT IN 叫 吗 名




口 口 口 口

口 口

06

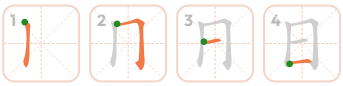
# 日

## rì sun, day

4 strokes

Once a circle with a dot in the middle: the sun. Write the frame like 口, add the middle line, then close the bottom.

LOOK FOR IT IN 是 (top part)




日 日 日 日

日 日

07

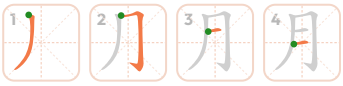
# 月

## yuè moon, month

4 strokes

A crescent moon. Draw the outside first, then the two short inner lines, which touch the left side only.

LOOK FOR IT IN 一月 yīyuè · January　大月　小月



月 月 月 月

月 月

08

# 女

## nǚ woman

3 strokes

A woman kneeling with her arms crossed. Start with the bent stroke, then the long left-falling stroke, and finish with the horizontal.

LOOK FOR IT IN 好　女人 nǚrén · woman



女 女 女 女

女 女

09

# 子

## zǐ child

3 strokes

A baby wrapped in a blanket with its arms out. The hooked turn at the top, then the long vertical hook, then the arms.

LOOK FOR IT IN 好　字



子 子 子 子

子 子

10

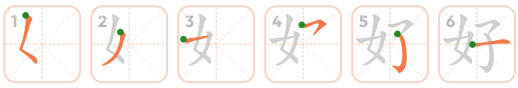
# 好

## hǎo good

6 strokes

女 woman + 子 child: a mother with her child is "good." Notice that 女 gets narrower here and its last stroke rises to the right.

LOOK FOR IT IN 你好 nǐ hǎo · hello



好 好 好 好

好 好

11

# 你

## nǐ you

7 strokes

亻 is 人 squeezed onto the left side, a clue that the character is about people. The right part is 尔 (ěr).

LOOK FOR IT IN 你好 你是...



你 你 你 你

你 你

12

# 我

## wǒ I, me

7 strokes

Originally a picture of a weapon with a jagged blade. One of the trickier stroke orders for beginners, so follow the diagram slowly and finish with the dot.

LOOK FOR IT IN 我是... 我叫...



我 我 我 我

我 我

13

# 是

## shì to be (am, is, are)

9 strokes

日 sits on top. Use 是 to link two nouns: 我是 Tom. It never changes form: I am, you are, she is are all 是.

LOOK FOR IT IN

我是… 不是



是 是 是 是

是 是

14

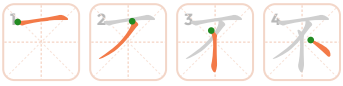
# 不

## bù not, no

4 strokes

Put 不 before a verb to make it negative. Tone tip: before a 4th tone, 不 turns into a 2nd tone, so 不是 is said bú shì.

LOOK FOR IT IN 不是 bú shì · is not



不 不 不 不

不 不

15

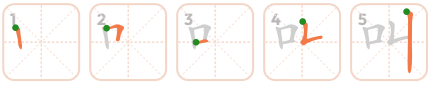
# 叫

## jiào to be called

5 strokes

口 mouth on the left: calling out is done with the mouth. 我叫… is the easiest way to say "my name is…"

LOOK FOR IT IN 我叫… 你叫…



叫 叫 叫 叫

叫 叫

16

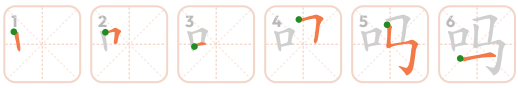
# 吗

## ma question particle

6 strokes

Add it to the end of a statement to make a yes/no question. 口 shows it is a spoken sound; 马 mǎ (horse) hints at the pronunciation.

LOOK FOR IT IN 你是小月吗?



17

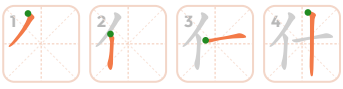
# 什

## shén what (in 什么)

4 strokes

亻 person + 十 ten. You will almost always meet it in the word 什么 shénme, "what."

LOOK FOR IT IN 什么 shénme · what



18

# 么

## me (in 什么)

3 strokes

Said with a light, neutral tone. On its own it means very little; paired with 什 it makes 什么, "what."

LOOK FOR IT IN 什么



19

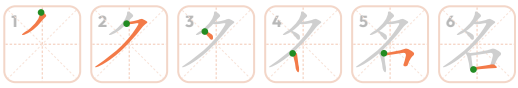
# 名

## míng name

6 strokes

夕 evening + 口 mouth. A classic memory story: in the dark nobody can see your face, so you call out your name.

LOOK FOR IT IN 名字 míngzi · name



20

# 字

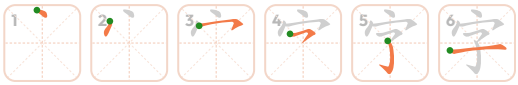
## zì character, word

6 strokes

宀 roof + 子 child: a child under a roof, learning to write. In 名字 míngzi (name) it takes a neutral tone.

LOOK FOR IT IN 名字

汉字 hànzì · Chinese characters



# 03 PART 3 Your First Conversation

说
shuō · to speak

Tom is looking for his friend 小月 Xiǎo Yuè. Every character below is one of the 20 you just wrote.

**Tom**
A learner meeting someone new.

**大月 Dà Yuè**
小月's older sister. Tom mixes them up.

**Tom**
你好！
**Nǐ hǎo!** Hello!

大月
你好！
**Nǐ hǎo!** Hi!

**Tom**
你是小月吗?
**Nǐ shì Xiǎo Yuè ma?** Are you Xiao Yue?

大月
不是，我不是小月。
**Bú shì, wǒ bú shì Xiǎo Yuè.** No, I'm not Xiao Yue.

**Tom**
你叫什么名字?
**Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?** What's your name?

大月
我叫大月。你叫什么名字?
**Wǒ jiào Dà Yuè. Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?** My name is Da Yue. What's your name?

**Tom**
我叫 Tom。
**Wǒ jiào Tom.** I'm Tom.

大月
你好，Tom！
**Nǐ hǎo, Tom!** Nice to meet you, Tom!

### 吗 MAKES A QUESTION

你是小月。 "You are Xiao Yue." Add 吗 and it becomes "Are you Xiao Yue?" No word order change needed.

### SAYING NO WITH 不是

Mandarin has no single word for "yes" or "no." You repeat the verb: 是 (it is) or 不是 (it isn't), said bú shì.

### FUN FACT

In the calendar, 大月 "big month" means a month with 31 days and 小月 "small month" a shorter one.

## 3.1 Now read it without pinyin

Cover the previous page and read the dialogue out loud. Can you remember what every line means?

A 你好！

B 你好！

A 你是小月吗?

B 不是，我不是小月。

A 你叫什么名字?

B 我叫大月。你叫什么名字?

A 我叫 Tom。

B 你好，Tom！

## 3.2 Your turn

Introduce yourself. Write the characters you know, and your name in letters.

你好！

我叫 _____ ○ Wǒ jiào … · My name is …

你叫什么名字? Ask your partner's name

我不是 _____ ○ Wǒ bú shì … · I'm not …

## 3.3 Your first 20 characters

Tick them off when you can write each one from memory, with the right stroke order.

| | | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 一 yī | 人 rén | 大 dà | 小 xiǎo | 口 kǒu | 日 rì | 月 yuè | 女 nǚ | 子 zǐ | 好 hǎo |
| 你 nǐ | 我 wǒ | 是 shì | 不 bù | 叫 jiào | 吗 ma | 什 shén | 么 me | 名 míng | 字 zì |

**YOU DID IT**

Pinyin, five tones, eight strokes, twenty characters, and a full conversation. That's a real foundation. Keep writing these characters every day this week and they will stay with you.

KEEP GOING

# Ready for your next 100 characters?

Our HSK-aligned textbooks and the Mandarin Zest Club pick up exactly where this workbook ends.

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